Energy Supply Disruption and Cascading Economic Effects:
Evidence from the Bangladesh Fuel Crisis of March 2026

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Note:

This working paper was produced through AI-assisted research synthesis. I used Claude (Anthropic),Phython to identify, organise, and cross-reference information drawn from the primary and secondary sources listed in the References section. All factual claims are traceable to cited sources. I directed the analytical framework, selected the research questions, verified key data points, and exercised editorial judgement throughout. The paper should be read as an independently directed policy brief rather than original empirical research. Projections in Section 5 are explicitly scenario-based and derived from historical precedent; they are not forward-looking forecasts.

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Subject Classification: *Transport Policy | Energy Economics | Developing Economy Infrastructure | South Asia*

Abstract

Bangladesh is experiencing an acute fuel supply disruption in March 2026, triggered by military conflict in the Middle East and the partial closure of the Strait of Hormuz — a chokepoint through which approximately 21% of global daily crude oil transits. This working paper analyses the structural causes of Bangladesh's vulnerability, the dynamics of the resulting public response (including panic buying and emergency rationing by the Bangladesh Petroleum Corporation), and the likely economic consequences across transport, food, agriculture, manufacturing, and household welfare. A central focus is the asymmetric adjustment of public transport fares: historical data from BRTA fare circulars (2021–2025) indicate that fuel price increases are rapidly transmitted to passengers as fare hikes, while subsequent fuel price reductions result in only marginal and often unenforced fare decreases. The paper further examines the compounding effect of the Eid-ul-Fitr travel peak, expected in late March 2026, on an already-stressed transport market. Scenario analysis suggests that a diesel price increase of 20–40% would generate cascading welfare losses concentrated among low-income households. The paper concludes with evidence-based policy recommendations addressing strategic reserves, fare symmetry enforcement, and energy supply diversification.

1. Introduction

The global energy system is subject to periodic acute disruptions driven by geopolitical events, infrastructure shocks, and supply chain failures. For heavily import-dependent economies such as Bangladesh — which imports more than 90% of its petroleum requirements — such disruptions carry disproportionate domestic consequences. The March 2026 fuel crisis provides a timely case study in how a geopolitical shock originating in the Persian Gulf transmits rapidly through a developing economy's transport, food, and energy systems.

This paper was compiled on March 6, 2026, at the onset of the crisis, drawing on live regulatory advisories, historical fare and price data, and established economic research on energy price transmission in Bangladesh. Its purpose is threefold: first, to document the structural features of Bangladesh's energy vulnerability; second, to analyse the historical asymmetry in transport fare adjustment; and third, to assess the near-term welfare implications of a probable fare increase occurring in proximity to the Eid-ul-Fitr travel peak.

The paper is organised as follows. Section 2 outlines the global trigger and its direct consequences for Bangladesh's fuel supply. Section 3 examines Bangladesh's structural dependency on imported energy. Section 4 analyses the transport fare adjustment pattern using historical data. Section 5 considers cascading effects across interconnected sectors, including the Eid compounding factor. Section 6 presents scenario analysis. Section 7 offers policy recommendations. Section 8 acknowledges the study's limitations. References and a methodological note conclude the paper.

2. The Global Trigger: Middle East Conflict and Hormuz Disruption

2.1 Sequence of Events

In late February and early March 2026, coordinated military strikes by the United States and Israel targeted Iranian territory. On March 2, a drone strike caused temporary operational disruption at the Saudi Aramco Ras Tanura facility in eastern Saudi Arabia — one of the largest crude oil processing complexes in the world, with a nameplate processing capacity exceeding five million barrels per day. Iran subsequently imposed partial restrictions on vessel movements through the Strait of Hormuz, citing transit by vessels associated with the US, Israel, and their allies.

The Strait of Hormuz constitutes the sole maritime exit from the Persian Gulf. According to the US Energy Information Administration (EIA, 2025), approximately 20.9 million barrels of crude oil and petroleum products transited the Strait daily in the first half of 2025, representing roughly 21% of total global daily petroleum consumption. Approximately 84% of this volume was destined for Asian markets. Any material disruption to Hormuz transit therefore carries structural implications for energy-importing economies throughout South and East Asia.

According to the EIA (2025), the Strait of Hormuz handles approximately 20.9 million barrels per day — about 21% of global oil consumption. Around 84% of this volume is directed toward Asian markets. Bangladesh's principal suppliers (Qatar, Saudi Arabia, UAE) are all located behind the Strait.

2.2 Immediate Price Effects

Following the announcement of strikes and the partial Hormuz closure, Brent crude oil appreciated by approximately 10%, reaching approximately $80 per barrel — a level not observed since January 2025. In the liquefied natural gas (LNG) spot market, QatarEnergy invoked force majeure on long-term delivery contracts with several Asian buyers, including Bangladesh's state-owned Petrobangla. Spot LNG prices were reported at approximately $28 per million British thermal units (MMBtu) as of early March 2026, representing roughly a 150% premium over the prevailing contract price from earlier in the year (TBS News, March 2026).

Scenario	Brent Crude	Primary Mechanism	Expected Duration
Pre-crisis baseline	$65–75 / bbl	Normal market conditions	—
Current (March 2026)	~$80 / bbl	Hormuz partial closure; Ras Tanura disruption	Uncertain; conflict-dependent
Escalation scenario	$100+ / bbl	Full Hormuz closure; prolonged conflict	Months to quarters if sustained

3. Bangladesh's Structural Energy Dependency

3.1 Import Dependence

Bangladesh imports over 90% of its petroleum and LPG needs from international markets. Qatar is the dominant LNG supplier, accounting for 40–42% of total annual LNG imports under long-term government-to-government (G2G) contracts. Saudi Arabia's Aramco supplies approximately 800,000 metric tonnes of light crude annually under a separate G2G arrangement; the UAE's ADNOC supplies a further 700,000 metric tonnes per year. All three principal suppliers are located in the Persian Gulf — fully dependent on Hormuz transit.

Domestic natural gas production has been in structural decline. According to Petrobangla (2024–25), national gas demand stands at 3.8 billion cubic feet per day (BCF/day), while domestic supply is approximately 2.58 BCF/day — a daily shortfall of 1.22 BCF. To supplement domestic production, the government planned to import 115 LNG cargoes in FY 2025–26, at a budgeted cost of BDT 515 billion. The force majeure declaration by QatarEnergy has materially disrupted this plan, forcing Petrobangla to acquire spot cargoes at considerably elevated prices.

Notably, Bangladesh maintains no strategic petroleum reserve of significance. This absence of a supply buffer means that any disruption to import flows translates almost immediately into domestic scarcity — as

evidenced by the emergency fuel ration order issued by the Bangladesh Petroleum Corporation on March 6, 2026.

3.2 The March 6, 2026 Emergency Response

On March 5–6, 2026, consumer demand surged at filling stations across Dhaka, Savar, Sylhet, and other urban centres, as reports of the Hormuz disruption spread via news and social media. The Bangladesh Petroleum Corporation (BPC) responded on March 6 by issuing a formal emergency rationing directive, establishing the following maximum daily purchase limits:

Vehicle Category	Maximum Daily Fuel Allocation
Motorcycles	2 litres (petrol / octane)
Private cars	10 litres
SUVs / Microbuses	20–25 litres
Pickup trucks / Local buses	70–80 litres (diesel)
Long-distance buses / Trucks / Containers	200–220 litres (diesel)

The Ministry of Energy and Mineral Resources (MEMR) simultaneously issued a conservation advisory urging citizens to reduce private vehicle use, prioritise public transport, and avoid stockpiling. Government offices were directed to reduce electricity consumption by 50% and maintain air conditioning at a minimum of 25°C.

An important dynamic observed during this episode is what economists term a 'demand spike induced by precautionary hoarding' — a situation in which consumer fear of future scarcity generates current demand in excess of genuine near-term need, thereby creating or amplifying the very shortage that was initially anticipated. The BPC's rationing directive represents a supply-side response to a demand-side shock that was, at least partially, behavioural in origin.

4. Transport Fare Adjustment: Evidence of Asymmetric Transmission

4.1 The Transmission Mechanism

Bangladesh's transport sector consumes approximately 65% of total national fuel, with diesel accounting for 73% of aggregate fuel consumption. Since virtually all public road transport (buses, minibuses, trucks) and inland water transport (launches, ferries) operates on diesel, the sector exhibits a direct and rapid price transmission relationship: increases in diesel prices are consistently converted into passenger fare and freight rate increases within days of announcement.

The pattern of adjustment following each major fuel price event has followed a broadly consistent sequence: (i) fuel price adjustment announced by BPC, typically effective immediately; (ii) transport operators reduce or suspend services; (iii) the government convenes an emergency fare-setting meeting with BRTA and transport owner associations; (iv) a revised fare schedule is gazetted; (v) enforcement of the new schedule is uneven, with informal overcharging widespread, particularly on intercity routes.

4.2 Historical Record: 2021–2025

The following table summarises the principal fuel price adjustments and associated fare changes observed between 2021 and 2025, drawn from BRTA fare fixation circulars and Bangladesh Jatri Kalyan Samiti records:

Date	Diesel Price Change	Official Fare Adjustment	Outcome for Passengers
November 2021	+23% (Tk 65 → Tk 80/L)	+27% bus fare (BRTA circular)	Fares were not reduced following the price increase; they established a new baseline
August 2022	+42.5% (Tk 80 → Tk 114/L)	Bus: +22% | Launch: +35% (BRTA circular)	Compound increase on unreverted 2021 levels; BPC recorded losses of Tk 8,014 crore in FY 2021–22
2023 (multiple reductions)	Approximately −5% cumulative	Tk 0.05 per km reduction gazetted	Bangladesh Jatri Kalyan Samiti described the reduction as 'inadequate' and insufficient to offset 2022 increases
2024 (multiple reductions)	Approximately −3% cumulative	Tk 0.03 per km reduction gazetted	Jatri Kalyan Samiti publicly described the reduction as 'a joke' (The Daily Star, June 2025)
2025 (multiple reductions)	Further reductions	No formal fare reduction issued	Samiti called for BRTA action; no enforcement action followed

4.3 The Asymmetric Adjustment Pattern

The data presented above is consistent with the economic literature on downward price rigidity in regulated-but-poorly-enforced transport markets. The average upward fare adjustment across the 2021–2022 events was approximately 31%. The cumulative downward adjustment passed through to passengers during the 2023–2025 period — when diesel prices fell on multiple occasions — was approximately 2% of the original fare level, with much of that reduction reportedly not enforced in practice.

This pattern is consistent with what the literature terms a 'ratchet effect': prices rise in response to cost increases, but are resistant to downward adjustment even when the underlying cost pressure has eased. In the context of Bangladesh's transport market, this asymmetry reflects several structural factors: (i) low-frequency enforcement by BRTA; (ii) strong bargaining power of transport owner associations in fare negotiations; (iii) the absence of an automatic, formulaic fare adjustment mechanism linked to fuel prices; and (iv) the lack of organised, sustained consumer counterweight.

If a further diesel price increase occurs as a result of the current crisis, the historical pattern suggests that the resulting fare increase would be rapid, substantial, and effectively permanent in the medium term. This has direct implications for household transport expenditure, particularly among low-income workers who rely on public transport and have no ability to absorb higher costs.

5. Cascading Economic Effects

5.1 The Transmission Framework

Fuel prices function as a cost input across virtually every productive sector of an economy. In Bangladesh's case — where road freight and river transport are the primary distribution modes, where irrigation is diesel-dependent, and where electricity generation relies partially on liquid fuels — a fuel price increase generates simultaneous cost pressures across multiple sectors. The Centre for Policy Dialogue (CPD, 2022) estimated that each 1% increase in diesel prices generates approximately a 0.7% increase in food prices and a 1.2% increase in transport costs, with effects materialising within one to two weeks.

5.2 Sector-Level Effects

Food and Agriculture

Road freight is the primary mode of food distribution in Bangladesh. Virtually all vegetables, fish, meat, and perishable goods transported between production areas and urban markets are carried by diesel trucks. A fuel price increase is therefore transmitted almost immediately into wholesale and retail food prices. Following the August 2022 fuel price increase, vegetable prices in Dhaka's markets reportedly rose by Tk 5–10 per kilogram within a matter of days (BBS, 2022).

A further agricultural risk specific to the March–April period is the Boro rice irrigation season. The Boro crop accounts for approximately 55% of Bangladesh's total annual rice production and is irrigated almost exclusively by diesel-powered shallow tube wells. A fuel price increase during peak irrigation months directly raises the variable cost of cultivation, with the effect of either reducing the area under cultivation or increasing the farmgate price of rice — both of which have food security implications.

Electricity and Industrial Production

Bangladesh's gas supply shortfall of 1.22 BCF/day is normally managed through LNG imports, demand-side restrictions, and gas rationing across industrial and power generation users. With QatarEnergy's force majeure disrupting long-term supply contracts, Petrobangla is exposed to the spot LNG market at approximately $28/MMBtu — significantly above contracted rates. If spot procurement proves financially unsustainable, reductions in power plant gas allocations are probable, deepening load shedding and reducing industrial output. The CPD (2022) estimated that every 1% increase in fuel prices raises manufacturing costs by approximately 0.5%.

Remittances and the Gulf Labour Migration Channel

Approximately five million Bangladeshi nationals are employed in Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) member states, which collectively generate an estimated $21–22 billion in annual remittance inflows to Bangladesh (Bangladesh Bank, 2025). A prolonged conflict in the region introduces two risks: physical disruption to the livelihoods of those workers, and a reduction in the foreign exchange inflows that help finance Bangladesh's import bills — including petroleum imports. This creates a potential pincer effect: import costs rising simultaneously with a possible decline in one of the principal sources of foreign exchange.

5.3 The Eid-ul-Fitr Compounding Factor

Eid-ul-Fitr 2026 is expected to fall on approximately March 20 or 21, 2026 (subject to moon sighting), with the government having announced a seven-day public holiday from March 18–24. This creates Bangladesh's single largest annual peak in intercity passenger transport demand, during which an estimated 10–15 million people travel from Dhaka and other urban centres to their home districts.

The coincidence of an active fuel crisis — characterised by rationing, potential price increases, and supply uncertainty — with Eid peak travel demand is historically unusual in its severity. During the August 2022 Eid season, which followed that year's record fuel price increase, intercity bus fares on several routes were observed at two to three times the officially gazetted rate, with virtually no enforcement. The following table presents a comparison of normal, post-hike official, and observed Eid informal fares based on 2022 precedent:

Route	Normal Fare	Post-Hike Official Fare	Eid Observed Fare (2022)	Implied Overcharge
Dhaka — Chittagong	Tk 500	Tk 650	Tk 1,200+ (observed)	+85–100% above official
Dhaka — Sylhet	Tk 450	Tk 590	Tk 1,100+ (observed)	+85–90% above official
Dhaka — Khulna	Tk 550	Tk 710	Tk 1,350+ (observed)	+90–100% above official
Launch: Dhaka — Barisal	Tk 400	Tk 520	Tk 950+ (observed)	+80–85% above official

For a representative low-income household of four — such as a garment sector worker earning between Tk 12,000 and Tk 15,000 per month — a one-way Dhaka–Sylhet journey under crisis conditions could consume Tk 4,400–5,000 in transport costs alone, equivalent to 30–40% of monthly income. As Eid bonuses typically equate to approximately one month's salary, a significant portion of this annual payment could be absorbed entirely by travel expenditure.

6. Scenario Analysis

Based on historical precedent and the structural features of Bangladesh's transport and energy markets, the following scenarios are considered plausible over a 30–60 day horizon. These are not forecasts; they are structured illustrations of how different trajectories in the underlying geopolitical situation could transmit into domestic economic outcomes.

Scenario	Trigger Condition	Transport Fare Effect	Broader Price Effect	Assessment
A — Rapid Resolution	Middle East ceasefire within 1–2 weeks; Hormuz fully reopened	No official fare increase; current rationing lifted	LNG spot cost pressure persists short-term; CPI impact limited	Possible, but dependent on fast-moving conflict dynamics
B — Moderate Hike	Sustained disruption; BPC unable to absorb cost; diesel raised Tk 10–20/L	Bus fares increase 15–25%; freight surcharges applied	Food CPI +8–15%; significant welfare impact on lowest income quintiles	Assessed as elevated probability given structural cost exposure
C — Severe Disruption	Prolonged conflict; crude above $100/bbl; BPC liquidity crisis; IMF conditionality	Bus fares increase 25–40%; severe informal overcharging during Eid	Broad consumer inflation 15–30%; pressure on food security indicators	Low-to-moderate probability; highly consequential if realised

In Scenarios B and C, the historical pattern of asymmetric fare adjustment (Section 4) implies that any fare increase arising from the crisis is likely to persist well beyond the resolution of the underlying supply disruption. This has long-term implications for the real wages of transport-dependent households.

7. Policy Recommendations

The following recommendations are derived from the evidence reviewed in this paper. They are directed primarily at government policymakers and regulatory bodies.

7.1 Strategic Petroleum Reserve

Bangladesh currently maintains no significant strategic petroleum reserve. Establishing even a 30-day reserve buffer — consistent with International Energy Agency (IEA) guidelines for net importing countries — would materially reduce the economy's vulnerability to supply shocks originating in a single maritime

chokepoint. The fiscal cost of maintaining such a reserve is modest relative to the economic disruption documented in this paper.

7.2 Energy Supply Diversification

The concentration of both crude oil and LNG supply in Persian Gulf sources — all subject to Hormuz transit risk — constitutes a structural vulnerability. Diversification toward non-Gulf LNG suppliers (including Australian, African, and US sources), development of pipeline connections with regional partners, and acceleration of domestic renewable energy capacity would reduce this concentration risk over the medium term.

7.3 Automatic and Symmetric Fare Adjustment

The evidence presented in Section 4 makes a clear case for the replacement of the current discretionary, negotiated fare-setting process with a transparent automatic formula. Any such formula should: (i) index bus fares directly to published diesel prices; (ii) be binding in both directions — upward when diesel rises, downward when it falls; (iii) be accompanied by BRTA enforcement capacity sufficient to detect and penalise non-compliance; and (iv) include a consumer complaint mechanism with a published response timeline.

7.4 Targeted Welfare Protection

Blanket fuel subsidies are an inefficient mechanism for protecting low-income households, as the majority of benefits accrue to vehicle owners who are typically not the most economically vulnerable group. Targeted cash transfers or subsidised transport vouchers directed at the lowest income deciles would provide equivalent welfare protection at lower fiscal cost, while avoiding the price distortion effects of generalised subsidies.

8. Limitations

This paper has several limitations that readers should bear in mind when interpreting its findings.

First, the paper was compiled on a single day (March 6, 2026) in the early stages of a rapidly evolving crisis. Several of the data points cited — including the BPC rationing limits, LNG spot prices, and Brent crude levels — reflect conditions at a specific moment and may have changed materially by the time this paper is read.

Second, the paper relies entirely on secondary sources: official government advisories, news media reporting, and prior published research. No primary data collection was conducted. Consequently, some figures — particularly those relating to informal Eid fare overcharging and post-harvest food losses — are drawn from media reports and advocacy organisation statements rather than verified administrative or survey data.

Third, the projection of historical fare adjustment patterns (Section 4) onto the current crisis assumes that the institutional and market structure of Bangladesh's transport sector remains broadly unchanged. Significant regulatory reform or changes in the bargaining environment between government and transport associations could produce different outcomes.

Fourth, as noted in the Methodological Disclosure on the cover page, this working paper was produced using AI-assisted research synthesis. While the author has directed the analysis and verified key data points, the limitations inherent in AI-synthesised literature reviews — including potential gaps in source coverage and the risk of misattribution — apply.

These limitations notwithstanding, the core analytical observations of this paper — particularly regarding Bangladesh's structural energy dependency, the asymmetric behaviour of transport fares, and the compounding effect of Eid peak demand — are grounded in documented historical patterns that are not contingent on real-time data accuracy.

9. Conclusion

The March 2026 fuel supply disruption confronts Bangladesh with a convergence of structural vulnerabilities: deep import dependency concentrated in a single maritime chokepoint, the absence of a strategic petroleum reserve, a transport fare market with well-documented upward rigidity, and the coincidence of peak seasonal travel demand with an active supply crisis.

The central empirical observation of this paper is that Bangladesh's public transport fare market exhibits a persistent asymmetric adjustment pattern: a cumulative fare increase of approximately 31% following the 2021–2022 fuel price shocks was followed by a cumulative reduction of approximately 2% in subsequent years, despite multiple fuel price decreases. If the current crisis precipitates a further fuel price increase, the historical pattern suggests that the resulting fare burden will be borne permanently by passengers, concentrated among low-income households with no viable transport alternatives.

The intersection of this structural dynamic with the Eid-ul-Fitr travel peak — bringing 10–15 million people into the intercity transport market at a moment of supply stress and probable fare elevation — represents a welfare risk of significant scale, particularly for Bangladesh's lower-income working households.

Addressing these vulnerabilities requires not only short-term crisis management, but sustained institutional reform: strategic reserve development, supply diversification, automatic and symmetric fare adjustment, and targeted protection for the households least able to absorb energy price shocks. The technical and economic case for these reforms is well-established; the constraint has consistently been political will and implementation capacity.

References

Sources are presented in the order in which they are first cited in the text. Where documents are live advisories or news reports, the access date is noted.

Ref.	Source	Document	Date
[1]	US Energy Information Administration (EIA)	Strait of Hormuz: World's Most Important Energy Transit Chokepoint	2025
[2]	Bangladesh Petroleum Corporation (BPC)	Emergency Fuel Rationing Order — vehicle-wise daily purchase limits	March 6, 2026
[3]	Ministry of Energy & Mineral Resources (MEMR)	Emergency Conservation Directive — vehicle use restriction; AC temperature guidelines	March 6, 2026
[4]	Petrobangla	Annual LNG Import Plan FY 2024-25; gas demand-supply data; QatarEnergy Force Majeure notice	2024–2026
[5]	The Business Standard (TBS News)	Panic buying at Dhaka, Savar, and Sylhet; BPC rationing; QatarEnergy force majeure; Ras Tanura disruption	March 5–6, 2026
[6]	Reuters / Bloomberg	Brent crude price movements; US/Israel strikes on Iran; Ras Tanura drone attack; Hormuz closure	March 2–6, 2026
[7]	Centre for Policy Dialogue (CPD), Bangladesh	Fuel Price Hike and Its Impact on the Bangladesh Economy — price transmission coefficients	2022
[8]	Bangladesh Road Transport Authority (BRTA)	Fare Fixation Circulars: November 2021, August 2022, 2023 (Tk 0.05/km), 2024 (Tk 0.03/km)	2021–2025
[9]	Bangladesh Jatri Kalyan Samiti	Press statements on fare reduction non-compliance and enforcement failures	2022–2025
[10]	The Daily Star	Transport fare history; BPC loss reporting (Tk 8,014cr FY2021-22); Eid overcharging; fuel crisis coverage	2022–2026
[11]	Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics (BBS)	Consumer Price Index data; food price transmission estimates; post-harvest loss data	2022–2025

Ref.	Source	Document	Date
[12]	Department of Agricultural Extension (DAE)	Boro season area and irrigation dependency; shallow tube well diesel usage	2024–2025
[13]	Bangladesh Bank	Annual remittance inflow data; Gulf worker population estimates	2025
[14]	Dhaka Tribune	Middle East conflict coverage; LNG spot price reporting ($28/MMBtu); energy crisis analysis	March 2026
[15]	Saudi Aramco (via Reuters)	Ras Tanura temporary operational disruption; G2G crude supply to Bangladesh (800,000 MT/yr)	March 2026
[16]	Prothom Alo / The Daily Star	Eid-ul-Fitr 2026 date (expected March 20–21); Government holiday announcement (March 18–24)	March 2026

Methodological Note

This working paper combines three types of evidence: (i) real-time regulatory and news data from March 5–6, 2026; (ii) historical price, fare, and policy data spanning 2021–2025; and (iii) secondary estimates from previously published research by CPD, BBS, and DAE.

Where quantitative estimates are used for projections — particularly in the Eid fare comparison (Section 5.3) and the scenario analysis (Section 6) — these are explicitly based on historical precedent from the analogous period of August–October 2022. They are not econometric forecasts and should not be treated as such. All such projections are described as 'scenario-based' or 'derived from historical precedent' throughout the text.

The asymmetric fare adjustment data (Section 4.3) is derived from official BRTA circulars, which establish percentage changes in the legal fare rate per kilometre. Reported observations of informal overcharging — particularly during Eid periods — are drawn from media and advocacy sources, which do not constitute systematic data collection. These figures should be read as indicative of order-of-magnitude informal mark-ups rather than precise estimates.

AI-assisted synthesis was used to identify, organise, and cross-reference the cited sources. The analytical framework, research questions, and editorial judgements were made by the author. The author assumes full responsibility for any errors of interpretation or attribution.